

JULIETA CLOSES IN ON THE BIG LEAGUE

The Argentinian's latest victory impressed Dana White enough for him to hint at a **new atomweight division.**

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"God's timing is perfect." This was the caption of a picture posted by 20-year-old MMA phenom Julieta

Martinez after a hard-fought split decision victory over Mexico's Leslie Hernandez in the Dana White Contender Series (DWCS). The DWCS is a mixed martial arts promotion, similar to *Road to UFC*, which serves as a stepping stone into the UFC.

Martinez had a shaky start to her strawweight bout against Hernandez. However, the Argentinian overcame her jitters before the second round began, continued to apply pressure,

and completely overpowered her opponent in the final 10 minutes.

Usually, after such a performance, fighters are awarded a UFC contract. However, Martinez's case was different, as she was the only grappler among the five winners not to earn one.

"Julieta, let me just say this: I cannot express how much we like you, and there is no doubt that you are incredibly talented, but you're just too young right now. You just turned 20, and you're undersized for the division," explained UFC CEO Dana White during a media interaction, as a disappointed Martinez watched from the sidelines.

Nevertheless, White was so impressed by her performance that he hinted the UFC might consider creating a new atomweight division (105 lbs), especially now that the promotion is bringing in more talent from South America and East Asia, regions that predominantly feature

smaller female athletes. Currently, the lowest weight class for women in the UFC is the strawweight division (115 lbs).

Other side of the spectrum

After proving his mettle in the NCAA Division 1 National Wrestling Championships with an impressive 120-3 record, American Bo Nickal shifted gears to pursue a career in professional MMA.

His remarkable debut at the iKON Fighting Championship put him on the global stage, earning him a spot in Season 6 of DWCS in 2022.

Since then, Nickal has succeeded each time he has stepped into the Octagon. At UFC 285: Jones vs Gane, in his UFC debut, he defeated Jamie Pickett in under three minutes, claiming his first Performance of the Night bonus.

At UFC 300, the 28-year-old extended his undefeated record to 6-0 by defeating Val Woodburn via a first-round TKO, followed by a submission victory over Cody Brundage.

UFC stars like Sean O'Malley and Jamahal Hill emerged from DWCS. Nickal, with similar potential, faces Paul Craig at UFC 309 in November, aiming to continue his impressive rise.

Young and hungry: The 20-year-old Julieta (left) earned a hard-fought split decision victory. GETTY IMAGES

